

Foreshortening

Objects receding toward the viewer

Foreshortening is the visual effect that makes an object appear shorter or compressed when it's oriented toward or away from the viewer. It's one of the most challenging but essential perspective skills.

KEY CONCEPTS

What It Is

When you point your arm directly at the viewer, your arm appears much shorter than its actual length. This is foreshortening. The more directly an object recedes toward the viewer, the more compressed it appears.

Why It's Hard

Our brains know how long an arm is and resist drawing it 'too short'. The solution: measure, don't think. Compare the foreshortened length to other measurements. Trust your observation over your assumption.

Ellipses as a Clue

When a cylinder (finger, limb, barrel) points toward you, the circles at each end become ellipses. The degree of the ellipse tells you how much foreshortening is occurring. Very flat ellipse = extreme foreshortening.

Overlapping to Aid Depth

Use overlapping shapes to reinforce the sense of depth in a foreshortened object. Multiple overlapping ellipses on a limb communicate far better than trying to draw the full length accurately.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw your own hand pointing directly toward you — study the foreshortening.
2. Draw a cylinder pointing at the viewer at 3 different angles.
3. Draw a foreshortened figure lying on the ground (feet toward viewer).

FURTHER READING

■ Proko – Foreshortening

<https://youtu.be/6ZXQX2QJxZE>

■ Draw a Box – Foreshortening

<https://drawabox.com/lesson/1>